

# Car Toon Guy

ANDHRA PRADESH



Driven by social issues, this entrepreneur crafts workable replicas and strange models of cars and bikes with scrap sourced from junk dealers



SUDHAKAR SHOWS OFF THE ODDBALL VEHICLES AT HIS MUSEUM

| By Amarnath K. Menon |

He is an innovator ready to promote a good cause. After spending 11 days building a cigarette-shaped bike, he put the 16-ft-long two-wheeler, powered by a 100-cc engine and emblazoned with a 'Break The Habit' slogan, on show for an hour in Hyderabad before cutting it into pieces. "I did this to drive home my message of giving up smoking. France, Ireland, Italy and several European countries are enforcing a ban on smoking in public places. I want smokers in India to respect this too," says Hyderabad-born car and bike designer Kanaboyina Sudhakar. The recent legislation on smoking in public places prompted Sudhakar to make the cigarette look-alike at a cost of Rs 12,000.

Major sporting events and social campaigns trigger Sudhakar's creative juices. His one-acre museum in Hyderabad that houses 200-odd unique miniatures and replicas of vintage and quaint models of cars and bikes draws over 1,000 visitors a day. Over the last 32 years, the 47-year-old has handcrafted cars in the shape of a helmet, a cricket bat, various balls, a burger, a mug, a

camera, a condom and a water closet. Most are powered by engines of old two-wheelers. He also made the largest tricycle in the world with a height of 41 ft, 7 inches and a length of 37 ft, 4 inches. It has a wheel diameter of 17 ft and weighs about three tonne.

Sudhakar, who funds his creative ventures through the family-owned printing press, now plans a women's series that will have cars and bikes in the shape of a lip-stick, stiletto, handbag besides a jewellery train. In his students' series, he is designing imitations of a notebook, a pen, pencil, and a sharpener. There are replicas of popular 20th century cars, including a Prosper Lambert of 1906, a Rolls Royce of 1910 and a Silver Ghost of 1925. Scrap sourced from junkyards in south Hyderabad goes into making Sudhakar's models which cost between Rs 40,000 and Rs one lakh.

The self-taught auto modeller is tinkering with the thought of making life-sized mechanised animals that walk, including a baby elephant, a bear, a turtle and a wild boar. He also plans a motorised adult elephant to carry two people. His road ahead is clear. ■